

Dubai Travel Guide

Quick Facts

- **Country:** United Arab Emirates (UAE)
- **Language:** Arabic (English widely spoken)
- **Currency:** UAE Dirham (AED, dhs)
- **Time Zone:** Gulf Standard Time (GST, UTC+4, no daylight saving)
- **Emergency Number:** 999 (police), 998 (ambulance), 997 (fire)
- **Dialing Code:** +971
- **Emirate:** Dubai (one of seven emirates in UAE)
- **Population:** ~3.6 million (over 90% expatriates)

Visa Requirements

Entry Rules by Nationality

Dubai (UAE) offers various visa options depending on nationality:

- **US Citizens:** Visa-free entry on arrival for **30 days** (can extend once for additional 30 days)
- **UK Citizens:** Visa-free entry on arrival for **180 days** within 12-month period
- **Canadian Citizens:** Visa-free entry on arrival for **30 days** (can extend)
- **Australian Citizens:** Visa-free entry on arrival for **30 days** (can extend)
- **EU Citizens:** Visa-free entry on arrival for **90 days** (varies by country)
- **GCC Citizens:** Free movement (Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, Bahrain, Oman, Qatar)
- **Other Nationals:** May need visa in advance - check [UAE Government portal](#)

Important Requirements

- **Passport Validity:** Must be valid for at least **6 months** from date of entry
- **Proof of Accommodation:** May be requested (hotel booking)
- **Return Ticket:** May be requested
- **No Israeli Stamps:** If passport has Israeli stamps/visas, entry may be denied (check current policy)
- **COVID-19:** Check current requirements (testing/vaccination may be required)

Visa Extension

- **One Extension:** 30-day visa can be extended once for additional 30 days (AED 600-850)
- **Where:** GDRFA (General Directorate of Residency and Foreigners Affairs) or authorized typing centers
- **Overstay Fines:** AED 200 for first day, AED 100 per day after - avoid overstaying!

Best Time to Visit

Winter (November - March)

- **Weather:** Perfect (18-30°C / 64-86°F), sunny, comfortable
- **Pros:** Ideal for outdoor activities, beach, desert safari, festivals (Dubai Shopping Festival, Dubai Food Festival)
- **Cons:** Peak tourist season, highest prices, crowded attractions
- **Best for:** First-time visitors, outdoor activities, beach, desert

Summer (April - October)

- **Weather:** Extremely hot (35-45°C / 95-113°F), can exceed 50°C in peak summer, humid
- **Pros:** Lowest prices (50%+ discounts on hotels), Dubai Summer Surprises shopping festival, indoor attractions
- **Cons:** Oppressive heat, impossible to do outdoor activities during day, uncomfortable
- **Best for:** Budget travelers, mall shopping, indoor attractions only

Shoulder Season (October, April)

- **Weather:** Hot but manageable (28-38°C / 82-100°F)
- **Pros:** Lower prices than winter, fewer crowds, still possible to do outdoor activities (early morning/evening)
- **Cons:** Still quite hot
- **Best for:** Budget-conscious visitors who can handle heat

Peak Season: November-March (book 2-3 months ahead) **Off Season:** June-August (incredible hotel deals but brutal heat)

Pro Tip: November-February is ideal. If visiting in summer, plan everything indoors - the heat is not to be underestimated!

Top Attractions

Attraction	Area	Entry Fee	Hours	Best Time to Visit	Must-Do Experience
Burj Khalifa	Downtown	AED 149-379 (levels vary)	8:30-23:00 (last entry)	Sunset (book Level 124/125)	At The Top observation deck
Dubai Mall	Downtown	Free (attractions vary)	10:00-midnight	Weekday afternoon (less crowded)	Aquarium, fountain show
Dubai Fountain	Downtown	Free	Shows every 30 min 18:00-23:00	Evening	Watch from Burj Park or bridge
Palm Jumeirah	Palm	Free (hotels/ attractions vary)	24/7	Any time	Monorail ride, beach clubs
Burj Al Arab	Jumeirah	High Tea ~AED 650	Advance booking required	Afternoon tea	High tea or dinner reservation
Dubai Marina	Dubai Marina	Free	24/7	Evening for Marina Walk	Dinner cruise, Marina Walk
Dubai Frame	Zabeel Park	AED 50	9:00-21:00	Sunset	360° views of old and new Dubai
Gold Souk	Deira	Free	10:00-22:00 (Fri 16:00-22:00)	Evening (cooler)	Bargain for gold jewelry
Spice Souk	Deira	Free	10:00-22:00	Morning or evening	Spices, textiles, souvenirs
Museum of the Future	DIFC	AED 145	10:00-20:00	Weekday morning	Futuristic exhibits
Desert Safari	Desert	AED 150-400	Afternoon/ evening tours	Sunset	Dune bashing, camel ride, BBQ dinner
Global Village	Dubailand	AED 25	Nov-Apr, 16:00-midnight	Evening	Cultural pavilions, shopping, food
Old Dubai	Bur Dubai/ Deira	Free (museums ~AED 3)	8:00-20:00 (varies)	Morning	Abra boat ride (AED 1!), museums

Insider Tips

- **Burj Khalifa:** Book online weeks ahead for sunset slots (most popular)
- **Dubai Fountain:** Free and spectacular - watch from terrace or bridge
- **Friday:** Islamic holy day - shops/malls open late (after 13:00), some offices closed
- **Dress Code:** Modest dress in malls, government buildings, old Dubai (covered shoulders/knees)
- **Summer Indoor:** Museums, malls, indoor ski slope, aquariums perfect for escaping heat

Neighborhoods & Districts

Downtown Dubai

- **Character:** Modern heart, skyscrapers, luxury, iconic landmarks
- **Must-See:** Burj Khalifa, Dubai Mall, Dubai Fountain, Souk Al Bahar
- **Food:** High-end restaurants, mall food courts, international chains
- **Transport:** Metro Red Line (Burj Khalifa/Dubai Mall station)
- **Stay Here If:** First-time visitor, want to be at the center of modern Dubai

Dubai Marina

- **Character:** Waterfront, high-rise living, expat hub, yacht culture
- **Must-See:** Marina Walk, JBR (Jumeirah Beach Residence) Beach Walk, Dubai Marina Mall
- **Food:** Beachfront dining, international restaurants, trendy cafes
- **Transport:** Metro Red Line (Dubai Marina, JBR stations), tram
- **Stay Here If:** Want beach + modern city, nightlife, dining options

Palm Jumeirah

- **Character:** Man-made palm-shaped island, luxury resorts, iconic
- **Must-See:** Atlantis The Palm, beach clubs, Nakheel Mall, Palm Monorail
- **Food:** Resort restaurants (expensive), beachfront dining
- **Transport:** Monorail from Gateway station, taxis
- **Stay Here If:** Luxury beach resort experience (expensive)

Old Dubai (Deira & Bur Dubai)

- **Character:** Historic Dubai, souks, Creek, traditional, authentic

- **Must-See:** Gold Souk, Spice Souk, Dubai Creek, abra boats, Al Fahidi Historical District, Dubai Museum
- **Food:** Traditional Emirati, Indian, Pakistani, budget-friendly
- **Transport:** Metro Green Line (Deira stations), abra boats across Creek
- **Visit For:** Cultural experience, bargaining at souks, budget dining

Jumeirah

- **Character:** Beachfront, upscale residential, expat families
- **Must-See:** Burj Al Arab, Jumeirah Beach, Jumeirah Mosque, Kite Beach
- **Food:** Beach clubs, international restaurants, cafes
- **Transport:** Buses, taxis (no metro)
- **Visit For:** Beach day, iconic Burj Al Arab photo, water sports

DIFC (Dubai International Financial Centre)

- **Character:** Financial district, upscale, art galleries, fine dining
- **Must-See:** Gate Avenue (luxury shopping/dining), art galleries, Museum of the Future nearby
- **Food:** Michelin-level restaurants, business lunch deals
- **Transport:** Metro Red Line (Emirates Towers)
- **Visit For:** Fine dining, art galleries, business

Food & Dining

Must-Try Emirati & Middle Eastern Dishes

- **Shawarma:** Grilled meat wrap (chicken/lamb) with tahini, pickles - street food staple (AED 5-10)
- **Hummus:** Chickpea dip with olive oil, served with Arabic bread
- **Falafel:** Fried chickpea balls, vegetarian staple
- **Mezze:** Selection of small dishes (hummus, moutabel, tabbouleh, etc.)
- **Al Harees:** Wheat and meat slow-cooked (traditional Emirati)
- **Machboos:** Spiced rice with meat (Emirati biryani)
- **Luqaimat:** Sweet fried dumplings with date syrup (dessert)
- **Arabic Coffee (Qahwa):** Cardamom-flavored coffee, served with dates
- **Dates:** Fresh dates (staple, offered as welcome)
- **Kunafa:** Shredded pastry with sweet cheese, soaked in syrup

Brunch Culture (Friday Brunch!)

- **What:** All-you-can-eat/drink buffets, Friday tradition (day off)
- **When:** Friday midday (12:00-16:00)
- **Cost:** AED 150-800+ depending on venue and alcohol inclusion
- **Where:** Hotels (Atlantis, Armani, Sofitel, etc.)
- **Pro Tip:** Book ahead, come hungry, pace yourself!

International Dining

Dubai is incredibly multicultural - every cuisine is represented:

- **Indian:** Large Indian population, excellent authentic restaurants
- **Filipino:** Many Filipino expats, great restaurants
- **Pakistani:** Karachi-style biryani, nihari, kebabs
- **Lebanese:** Shawarma, mezze, grills
- **Iranian:** Persian restaurants especially in Deira
- **Western:** All major chains (McDonald's, Starbucks, etc.)

Dining Customs

- **Alcohol:** Only served in licensed venues (hotels, clubs, some restaurants)
 - NOT in malls, street cafes, unlicensed restaurants
 - Expensive (AED 40-70 for beer, AED 80+ for cocktails)
 - Public intoxication is illegal and taken seriously
- **Pork:** Only available in hotel/licensed venues (separated "non-halal" section)
- **Halal:** Vast majority of food is halal
- **Ramadan:** No eating/drinking in public during daylight (restaurants closed or curtained)
- **Right Hand:** Use right hand for eating (left hand considered unclean)
- **Tipping:** 10-15% appreciated but often included as service charge

Where to Eat

- **Street Food:** Shawarma stands, Pakistani/Indian cafeterias (budget-friendly)
- **Food Courts:** Malls have extensive food courts (AED 30-50 per meal)
- **Restaurants:** Range from budget (AED 50-100) to fine dining (AED 500+)
- **Hotel Brunch:** Friday brunch tradition (AED 200-800)

Price Guide

- **Budget:** AED 20-50 (shawarma, Indian cafeteria, food court)
- **Mid-Range:** AED 100-200 per person (casual restaurants)
- **Fine Dining:** AED 400+ per person (Michelin-level, hotel restaurants)
- **Alcohol:** Adds significantly to bill (AED 40-70 per drink)

Transportation

From Dubai International Airport (DXB)

- **Metro Red Line:** To city center (15-30 min, AED 5-7.50), terminals 1 & 3
- **Taxi:** Metered from airport (AED 50-120 depending on destination), 20-40 min
- **Uber/Careem:** Similar to taxi (Careem is local app, cheaper than Uber)
- **Bus:** RTA buses to various areas (cheap but slow)

From Al Maktoum Airport (DWC)

- **Taxi:** Only option (AED 100-150 to city), 40-60 min
- **Uber/Careem:** Similar to taxi
- **Note:** Far from city, used mostly for budget airlines

Metro (Excellent!)

- **Lines:** Red Line (main tourist line), Green Line (old Dubai)
- **Coverage:** Connects airport, Downtown, Marina, many major attractions
- **Hours:** Sat-Wed 5:00-midnight, Thu 5:00-01:00, Fri 10:00-01:00
- **Tickets:** Nol Card (stored value), single journey AED 3-8.50
- **Cleanliness:** Very clean, modern, air-conditioned (essential!)
- **Women/Children Carriage:** Front carriage reserved (pink sign)
- **Gold Class:** More expensive carriage (double price)

Nol Card (Essential!)

- **What:** Contactless smart card for all public transport
- **Types:** Red (single use), Silver (rechargeable - best for tourists), Gold (premium)
- **Where to Buy:** Metro stations, RTA offices, some supermarkets

- **Cost:** Silver card AED 25 (AED 19 credit + AED 6 card fee)
- **Zones:** Dubai is divided into zones (most tourist areas in Zone 1)
- **Top-Up:** At stations or authorized outlets

Taxis (Regulated & Safe)

- **Regulated:** Dubai Taxi Corporation (cream color), RTA-licensed private taxis
- **All Metered:** Starting fare AED 12-25 depending on time/area
- **Apps:** Dubai Taxi app, Careem (local, cheaper), Uber
- **Costs:** AED 1.96-2.36 per km
- **Tipping:** Round up or 10% appreciated
- **Safe:** Very safe, drivers are professional, meters regulated

Careem vs Uber

- **Careem:** Local ride-hailing app, cheaper, more drivers, cash option
- **Uber:** International app, similar pricing, credit card only
- **Recommendation:** Download both, compare prices (Careem usually cheaper)

Tram

- **Coverage:** Dubai Marina, JBR area
- **Useful For:** Marina area, Palm Jumeirah connection
- **Nol Card:** Same card as metro

Driving

- **Rental:** Available but expensive with insurance
- **License:** International Driving Permit required for tourists
- **Traffic:** Can be heavy, aggressive drivers
- **Parking:** Paid in most areas
- **Salik:** Electronic toll gates (add to rental fee)
- **Not Necessary:** Public transport and taxis excellent for tourists

Abra Boats (Must Try!)

- **What:** Traditional wooden boats across Dubai Creek
- **Cost:** AED 1 per crossing (cheapest Dubai experience!)
- **Routes:** Deira to Bur Dubai, multiple crossing points

- **Experience:** Authentic, scenic, must-do in Old Dubai

Cultural Tips & Customs

Islamic Culture & Dress Code

Dubai is an Islamic emirate with modern tolerance, but respect local customs:

- **Modest Dress:** Required in malls, government buildings, mosques
 - Women: Cover shoulders and knees minimum (no need for headscarf except mosques)
 - Men: Shoulders covered, no shorts in government buildings
 - Beach/pool: Swimwear acceptable, but cover up when leaving
- **Ramadan:** Month of fasting (dates vary)
 - No eating/drinking/smoking in public during daylight
 - Restaurants closed or curtained during day
 - Respect fasting - don't eat in front of people
 - Evening is festive with iftars (breaking fast meals)

Public Behavior

- **Public Affection:** Holding hands okay, kissing/hugging not acceptable
- **Swearing:** Public swearing is illegal and can result in fines/arrest
- **Photography:** Don't photograph people (especially women) without permission, no photos of government/military buildings
- **Respect:** Avoid rude gestures (middle finger, thumbs up can be offensive in some contexts)

Alcohol & Substances

- **Alcohol:** Only in licensed venues (hotels, clubs)
 - NOT in public places, beaches, parks
 - Public intoxication is illegal (can be arrested/deported)
 - Drinking and driving: Zero tolerance (AED 25,000 fine + jail)
 - Bringing alcohol from airport duty-free requires license (tourists get temporary allowance)
- **Drugs:** Zero tolerance - even trace amounts in blood/urine can result in imprisonment
 - Some prescription medications are banned (check before travel)
 - Codeine, CBD, even poppy seeds can cause issues

Friday (Islamic Holy Day)

- **Day Off:** Weekend is Friday-Saturday
- **Mosques:** Friday prayers ~12:00-14:00 (major religious time)
- **Shops:** Open late (after 13:00-14:00)
- **Brunch:** Friday brunch is institution (hotels, restaurants)

Greetings & Interaction

- **As-salamu alaykum:** "Peace be upon you" (formal Arabic greeting)
- **Right Hand:** Always use right hand for greetings, eating, giving/receiving
- **Men & Women:** Handshakes between opposite genders only if initiated by woman
- **Titles:** Sheikh (ruler/leader), Emirati nationals hold high social status

Do's and Don'ts

DO: - Dress modestly in public (shoulders/knees covered in malls) - Remove shoes when entering someone's home - Accept Arabic coffee and dates when offered (hospitality) - Ask before photographing people - Respect prayer times (shops may close briefly)

DON'T: - Drink alcohol in public places (illegal) - Public displays of affection beyond holding hands - Eat/drink/smoke in public during Ramadan daylight hours - Swear or make rude gestures in public - Photograph government buildings or military installations - Bring banned substances (drugs, pork in public, etc.)

Language Tips

- **English:** Widely spoken (business language)
- **Arabic Phrases:**
 - As-salamu alaykum: Peace be upon you (greeting)
 - Shukran: Thank you
 - Afwan: You're welcome
 - Inshallah: God willing (used constantly)
 - Yalla: Let's go / hurry up
 - Habibi/Habibti: My dear (friendly term)

Safety & Health

Extremely Safe

Dubai is one of the world's safest cities:

- **Low Crime:** Very low violent crime rate
- **Safe to Walk:** Day and night, even for solo women
- **Strict Laws:** Harsh penalties deter crime
- **Tourist Police:** Dedicated tourist police available
- **Safety:** You're more likely to get a fine for jaywalking than be a crime victim

What Can Get You in Trouble

- **Drugs:** Zero tolerance (imprisonment, deportation)
- **Alcohol:** Public intoxication, drinking in public (arrest, fines)
- **Public Affection:** Kissing, inappropriate touching (fines, possible arrest)
- **Swearing:** Public profanity (fines, arrest)
- **Debt:** Bounced checks, unpaid debts (can result in imprisonment - unique to UAE)
- **Disrespecting Islam:** Blasphemy or insulting Islam/rulers (serious offense)

Traffic & Road Safety

- **Aggressive Drivers:** Drive carefully, be defensive
- **Jaywalking:** Illegal and dangerous (high fines, dangerous due to fast traffic)
- **Zebra Crossings:** Use designated crossings, drivers should stop but be cautious

Health & Medical

- **Excellent Healthcare:** World-class hospitals and clinics
- **Expensive:** No public healthcare for tourists - insurance essential
- **Hospitals:** Dubai Healthcare City, American Hospital, Rashid Hospital
- **Pharmacies:** Many 24-hour pharmacies (Boots, Life Pharmacy)
- **Insurance:** Mandatory for visa in some cases, essential for tourists
- **Prescriptions:** Bring enough medication + prescription (some drugs banned)

Heat Safety

- **Summer Heat:** Can exceed 50°C / 122°F - serious health risk
- **Dehydration:** Drink 3-4 liters water daily in summer
- **Sunstroke:** Limit outdoor time 11:00-16:00 in summer
- **AC Everywhere:** Taxis, metro, malls all heavily air-conditioned (bring light jacket!)

Emergency Numbers

- **Police:** 999
- **Ambulance:** 998
- **Fire:** 997
- **Tourist Police:** 800 4438 (800 DHET)

Practical Information

Electricity

- **Voltage:** 220-240V, 50Hz
- **Plug Type:** Type G (3-pin rectangular, British-style)
- **Adapter:** Essential for US/EU plugs
- **Where to Buy:** Airports, electronics stores, hotels sometimes provide

Money & Banking

- **Currency:** UAE Dirham (AED, dhs)
- **Exchange Rate:** Pegged to USD (~AED 3.67 = \$1 USD)
- **ATMs:** Everywhere, accept international cards
- **Credit Cards:** Widely accepted (Visa/Mastercard, Amex common)
- **Cash:** Still useful for souks, small shops, taxis (though cards increasingly accepted)
- **Tipping:** 10-15% appreciated (sometimes included as service charge)

Daily Budget

- **Budget:** AED 200-350 (hostels, street food, metro, free attractions)
- **Mid-Range:** AED 500-1,000 (hotels, restaurants, attractions, some taxis)
- **Luxury:** AED 2,000+ (5-star hotels, fine dining, experiences, shopping)

Note: Dubai can be expensive but also offers budget options. Shop at souks, eat street food, use metro to save money.

Costs

- **Alcohol:** Very expensive (AED 40-80 per drink)
- **Taxis:** Reasonable (AED 25-80 for most trips)
- **Food:** Wide range (AED 10 shawarma to AED 500+ fine dining)
- **Attractions:** Moderate to expensive (AED 50-400)

Business Hours

- **Shops/Malls:** 10:00-22:00 or midnight (varies)
- **Souks:** 10:00-22:00 (Fri 16:00-22:00)
- **Offices:** Sun-Thu 9:00-17:00 (Friday-Saturday weekend)
- **Restaurants:** Vary, many open all day

Internet & SIM Cards

- **Providers:** Du, Etisalat (both government-owned)
- **Tourist SIM:** AED 100-200 for 7-30 days with data
- **Where to Buy:** Airport (convenient), provider shops, supermarkets
- **WiFi:** Free in malls, cafes, hotels
- **Note:** VoIP (WhatsApp calls, Skype) often blocked (use VPN)

Public Toilets

- **Available:** Malls, mosques, attractions (free, clean)
- **Clean:** Generally very clean
- **Bidets:** Common in Middle East (spray hose)

Useful Apps

- **Careem:** Ride-hailing (essential)
- **Uber:** Alternative ride-hailing
- **RTA Dubai:** Public transport
- **Zomato/Deliveroo:** Food delivery
- **The Entertainer:** Dining discounts (buy-one-get-one)

Shopping

- **Malls:** Dubai Mall (world's largest), Mall of the Emirates (indoor skiing), Ibn Battuta
 - **Souks:** Gold Souk, Spice Souk, Textile Souk, Perfume Souk
 - **Bargaining:** Expected at souks (start at 40-50% of asking price)
 - **VAT Refund:** 5% VAT refundable for tourists (min AED 250 purchase)
 - **Dubai Shopping Festival (DSF):** January-February, mega sales and discounts
 - **Dubai Summer Surprises:** July-August, summer sales
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Travel Responsibly: Dubai is a Muslim city in a conservative region. Respect local customs, dress modestly in public, avoid public affection, and be mindful during Ramadan. The city welcomes tourists but expects visitors to respect Emirati culture and Islamic values.

Pro Tip: Dubai is incredibly diverse - over 200 nationalities live here. Embrace the multiculturalism, try different cuisines, and remember that the strict rules (no public drinking, modest dress, no PDA) are there to maintain harmony in a diverse society. Don't be intimidated - just be respectful and you'll have an amazing time. And seriously, don't underestimate the summer heat - if visiting June-August, plan EVERYTHING indoors!